

like Delhi-Jaipur, Delhi-Dehradun, Chennai-Bengaluru, and many others. These buses have metro rail's capacity, but metro costs ₹450 crore per km, while these buses cost ₹2 crore each. The ticket price will be 30% less than diesel buses. They will be air-conditioned with executive seats, and passengers will get amenities like tea, snacks, like in airplanes. Each seat will have a TV in front.

We are also building 360 ropeway cable cars. Earlier, this was only considered for tourism, but now we are slowly working on it to transport

there will be a big transformation in the transport sector soon.

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Do you think trade tensions will adversely affect our economy and exports?

When I became minister, India's automobile sector ranked seventh in the world. Six-and-a-half months ago, we overtook Japan and reached the third rank. America is first at ₹78 lakh crore, China second at ₹49 lakh crore, and India is ₹22 lakh crore. Interestingly, our automobile sector employs about 45 million youth, and it is

Now electric vehicles are so popular that there is a waiting list. Electric buses: 500 made yearly, but demand is for 100,000. Electric tractors and trucks are arriving. Battery chemistry has improved greatly—the lithium-ion battery cost was \$150 per kWh when we started, now it is \$55 per kWh in India. A bus battery costing ₹40 lakh then will now cost a third of that.

The day is near when petrol, diesel and electric vehicles will be priced equally. Hydrogen is also emerging. Young Indian researchers are working on lithium-ion, zinc-ion,

mining reforms and faster clearances. I am closely related to the automobile sector, so I am telling you this: Hydrogen fuel flex-engine vehicles are here. The world's first Innova running 100% on bio-ethanol is parked [here at the venue]. It generates 60% electricity and its petrol-equivalent cost is ₹25 per litre. It benefits consumers, reduces pollution, and helps farmers. I believe India will grow fast in this sector, providing top quality at the lowest cost worldwide, capturing a large market and strengthening the economy.

“I CHALLENGE ANYONE TO PROVIDE EVIDENCE OF PROBLEMS WITH ETHANOL USE. OPPOSITION MAY ARISE DUE TO VESTED INTERESTS”

containers from ports via ropeways. Overall, we have started 10 pilot projects on hydrogen in India involving firms like Tata, Leyland, Volvo, Indian Oil, HPCL, Reliance, and others. The Tata group has made three trucks—one on hydrogen fuel cells and two with internal combustion engines running on hydrogen. We are working on hydrogen filling stations, transportation of hydrogen, and green hydrogen production. The work has started, and

the biggest GST revenue generator for the state and Centre. Our biggest export is from this sector. Our two-wheeler industry exports 50% of its production. Mercedes-Benz's chairman met me about one-and-a-half months ago and said they are shifting completely to electric and will make India their manufacturing centre. Maruti Suzuki, Toyota, Hyundai have big exports. There is a big change: alternative fuels and bio-fuels are progressing fast.

aluminium-ion, and sodium-ion batteries. India has great potential to supply the world. Only one or two countries are somewhat ahead, but India will lead and capture the global market, strengthening our economy.

We need to start mining lithium quickly. Our mining minister and the PM have asked for this to be sped up because India has lithium deposits but currently imports lithium and gold. We aim for self-reliance with active

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There is a debate raging on social media about vehicle mileage suffering due to E20 ethanol blended fuel...

Not a debate, just rumours. Some politicians or the petroleum lobby could be behind this. Tell me one case where a vehicle had a problem due to 20% ethanol blending. The Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) and the Automotive Research Association of India (ARAI) have stated